

Project Brief

Relevant timeline	Michaelmas Term ☐	Lent Term ☒
Client name	InsideGate	
Industry	Career Services and Coaching/ Professional Networking	
Project sponsor	Alexander Schartz	
Contact name & position	Adrian Kräubig Co-Founder	
Project title	Go to market strategy	
Location (city, country)	London, United Kingdom	
Preferred contact email	akraeubig@gmx.de	
Company background	Website: <i>TBU</i> ● Foundation Year: 2024 ● Development Stage: Proof of Concept/Business Plan Development ● Investment Status: No investments applied for and received yet ● Founders: Adrian Kräubig and Sebastian Darius – no other team members to date ● Business Concept: A web-based marketplace designed for prospective applicants to seek advice from professionals in sought-after and competitive industries such as investment banking and consulting. Recognising the importance of networking in these fields, the startup aims to facilitate connections and advice from current employees to aspiring students. Currently, prospective candidates are dependent on the good will of professionals to help them, unless they can leverage their alumni and social network. The solution would democratise access into the most prestigious careers to applicants with more diverse backgrounds. ● Market Need: Students frequently seek advice from investment banking professionals/strategy consultants, primarily via LinkedIn or their company email address. These outreaches are mostly unsolicited and don't lead to valuable exchanges due to a lack of incentive to answer and an overwhelming number of messages on the side of the professionals - many not even tailored to the specific competencies/role of the recipient. Existing platforms facilitating such exchanges like <i>Wallstreet</i>	

	<i>Oasis</i> and <i>Evisors</i> primarily focus on the US market, offering limited support and geographical reach. They only have a limited number of coaches in the U.K. and do not cooperate with student societies and universities. ● Unique Value Proposition: The platform offers students the opportunity to talk directly to experienced professionals in their target industry or position. The coaches can advise them on every step of their applications and help them prepare for their interviews with first-hand insights in contrast to general application coaches or their universities' career centres. Unlike its competitors, this startup focuses on providing a GenZ-friendly designed, easy to filter catalogue of the most suitable professionals to support the prospective applicants with a geographical focus on London-based professionals. ● Monetisation Strategy: Users pay to book a meeting with professionals. The platform facilitates the match with a suitable advisor through search filters, a booking system and compelling UI/UX as well as handling all administrative tasks for the coaches. The platform keeps a percentage of the coaching fees. ● Current Progress: Webpage development is underway with an anticipated launch timeline. The platform will start enlisting mentors in January 2024, and it is set to open for student users by early March 2024. This represents a first proof of concept in the new geographic market. Parallel to becoming operative, they seek to enter an accelerator programme. ● Initial Market Focus: The United Kingdom, with a primary emphasis on the investment banking and strategy consulting industry. Current platforms do cooperate with U.S. universities but such co-operations don't exist with U.K. institutions or their investment/consulting student societies. The company will focus on developing relationships with student societies and university career centres in the U.K. and later in continental Europe.
Project outline/ objectives	<i>Background</i> The current focus of the startup is on enlisting a first cohort of investment banking/consulting mentors, ensuring a selection of knowledgeable and experienced professionals. Concurrently, the team will be finalising the website for launch, prioritising an intuitive, user-friendly, and fully functional platform MVP, ready to handle anticipated student interactions. The subsequent phase involves the acquisition of U.K. students interested in investment banking/consulting careers, necessitating targeted marketing efforts and outreach for user attraction.

The platform's go-live is slated for March 2024, marking a crucial milestone for testing its market acceptance and functionality. Success post-launch will be measured through revenue generation, the number and quality of mentor-student connections, and user feedback, all crucial indicators of the platform's effectiveness.

This initial launch not only serves as a proof of concept but also as a foundation for future expansion, contingent on the achievement of strong performance metrics. Following the launch, the company aims to participate in an accelerator-programme.

Maximising the chances of success involves a multifaceted approach, encompassing robust marketing strategies, seamless technological execution, and continuous feedback loops for iterative improvements in an effort to isolate success factors.

The objectives of this project are centred around maximising the chances of a successful website launch measuring its success and potentially adapting the marketing strategy post launch.

Deliverables

I. Business Case Analysis (BCA)

(1) Pricing strategy

Objective: To create a robust, market-aligned pricing strategy, ensuring competitiveness and attractiveness to the target segment (prospective applicants).

☑ Main question to be answered: What price(s) should be charged?

- **Benchmarking**

- Conduct an in-depth analysis of competitor pricing models. Consider the coaches' employer prestige/ranking, seniority, coaching experience/review, industry and try to establish other factors and their impact on the prices that coaches can charge.
- Assess market standards and average rates for similar coaching services.

- **WTP analysis**

- Conduct surveys with a representative and diverse enough sample of prospective applicants, focus groups or use other primary research methods to gauge U.K. students' WTP for offered coaching services by current employees of their target companies. The client will create a template for the survey. (One workstream member please request access to the premium version through LSE a week prior to kick-off:

<https://info.lse.ac.uk/staff/divisions/dts/services/qualtrics>
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- **Pricing Model Formulation**

- Evaluate and recommend suitable pricing models, including subscription-based, per-session charges, and tiered packages.
- Consider flexibility and user preferences in the pricing model design.
- Develop a multi-factor pricing model for the coachings based on the results from the benchmarking, WTP and mentor remuneration analyses. Calculate a suggested price for a coaching session/service based on the most important factors you identified (e. g.: coaches' employer prestige/ranking, seniority, coaching experience/review, industry).

- **Initial User Incentives**

- Propose bespoke strategies for initial user acquisition in line with the online and offline marketing strategy, considering free trial periods, referral bonuses, promotional pricing and more in a synopsis. Seamless integration leaving as little room for loopholes as possible.
- Plan the implementation, timeline and duration for these incentives.

(2) Mentor remuneration

Objective: Establish a taxonomy of compensation for the coaches based on factors such as their seniority, employer, and previous coaching experience as well as preparational effort and types of services. Scrape data from other providers and conduct primary research for two groups to validate how far off the prices on the platforms are (example: wait in front of bank offices and briefly interview a set of bankers).

☐ Main question to be answered: What compensation do coaches expect for their services?

(3) Contribution margin estimate

Objective: To calculate the impact of different pricing and remuneration models on the contribution margin of the startup and to derive the attainable ranges and optimal points for both metrics. How much commission can the company charge the coaches (WSO charges approx. 25-35%)?

☐ Main question to be answered: How much money will be left over to cover fixed costs?

II. Positioning & Offering Benchmark

Objective: To offer a comprehensive overview of services offered in the students-professionals on-demand coaching vertical, allowing to optimally tailor the start-ups USP and get the market fit right the first time.

📌 Main question to be answered: What comprises the ideal offer catalogue?

- **Direct Competitor Benchmarking**

- Identify all relevant direct competitors available in the U.K. market.
- Analyse the range of services and bundles offered by direct competitors.
- Evaluate their value propositions & service quality (number and quality of coaches as well as website design and UX).

- **Indirect Competitor Assessment**

- Investigate alternative methods students use to build networks and make contacts at target employers, such as LinkedIn, university alumni networks, industry events, and online forums.
- Analyse their effectiveness and limitations.

- **Market Positioning Visualisation**

- Utilise a multi-dimensional coordinate system to map competitors according to selected criteria such as service range (x-axis), pricing (y-axis), user experience (number showing ranking vs. competitors), and market presence (bubble size).
- Identify market niches, saturated areas, and opportunities for the startup, including potential B2B use cases extending the value chain (e. g.: university career centres or the HR of companies and their referral systems).

III. Website UX/ UI & Analytics

Objective: To deliver a detailed set of recommendations for developing a user-friendly, intuitive website with strong UX/UI design, leveraging competitive benchmarking and mystery shopping insights.

📌 Main question to be answered: How can the website conciliate a professional design with GenZ preferences? Which features are essential and which ones are nice to have ?

- **Competitive Benchmarking**

- Find best-in-class websites that resonate with GenZ in design and user-friendliness within the spectre of professional/credible websites.
- Analyse competitor websites such as Wallstreet Oasis and Evisors, for their UX/UI features in terms of strengths and weaknesses
- Assess features and functionalities (e. g.: payment options), design, navigation (including steps for sign-up), and user interaction tools (e. g.: chatbots, helplines).
- Evaluate overall user satisfaction through ratings, comments in forums, and direct feedback.
- **Mystery Shopping**
 - Conduct mystery shopping on competitors' websites to gain first-hand experience of their user journey.
 - Identify gaps and areas where competitors excel.
- **Website Statistics Tracking Recommendations**
 - Advise on key website metrics to track for continuous improvement, such as user engagement rates, conversion rates, bounce rates, and user feedback.

IV. Marketing Plan

Objective: To develop a marketing plan that effectively reaches the target segment of U.K. students, maximises website traffic at launch, and allows the platform to gain traction right from the onset.

❑ Main question to be answered: How to attract as many students onto the platform as quickly as possible?

- **Channel Strategy:** Determine the most effective channels for reaching the target audience. This may include digital platforms (social media, email, online forums), influencers, career fairs, and industry events.
 - **Partnership and Collaboration Strategy:** Identify and analyse potential partners (e. g.: universities, career services, educational influencers, industry organisations and technical training providers) for collaboration to enhance reach and credibility.
 - **Messaging and Content Plan:** Develop clear and compelling messaging that resonates with the target audience. Create a content plan that includes the types of messages, content formats (blogs, videos, testimonials), and key value propositions to be highlighted.
 - **Communication Timeline:** Outline a timeline for communication activities, considering optimal frequencies and
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timings for maximum engagement (incl. the recruitment cycles of banks/consulting firms)

- **Budget and Resource Allocation:** Establish a minimum budget for the marketing activities and allocate resources accordingly (incl. expenses on online marketing, GoogleAds etc.). Highlight, where to expect the best Marketing RoI.
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